

Relieving India's Language Stress

The creation of India required unifying the languages of India to effectively and efficiently conduct the businesses of the Governments/Institutions of the union, states, and territories of India. This language unification exercise rolled out by our constitution and pursued by the governments for several years has resulted in an official languages status quo within governments, however the language stress persists within society. This paper tries to analyse the causes for language stress and provides an approach to relieve the stress by redefining the language problem and making changes in governments approach to solve the problem.

The official languages evolution

The constitution effected in 1950 provided the legal framework to achieve the official language(s) alignment for India. It provided the following guidelines for the choice of languages.

Union level:

- i. Hindi or English: When making a choice, to show due regard to industrial, cultural and scientific advancement and interest of non-Hindi speaking regions in choice of language (Art. 344(3))
- ii. Hindi promotion: To promote Hindi so that it serves as a medium of expression for all of India by also assimilating the forms, styles and expressions of other regional languages (Art. 351)

State level:

- i. State language(s) promotion: To promote regional languages(s) spoken by sections of population of the state - (Art. 347)

The constitution also provided a starting point for the choice of official languages. It declared Hindi as the official language of the union with English as the second official language. It allowed the states and territories to adopt their own regional language(s)/English/Hindi as official language(s). It provided a grace period of 15 years for the union, states and territories to align their official languages.

The union has so far not been able to persuade ALL states and territories to adopt Hindi as an official language which would then pave the way for the union to think about legislating to remove English from the official languages list of the union.

- In 1963, given that Hindi was not adopted by all states/territories, the union passed the "The official Languages Act" to continue the two language (Hindi + English) formula for businesses of the union.
- In 1968, The union passed the "The official Language Resolution" to propose a 3-language formula; (Hindi + English + Regional) for Hindi speaking states/territories; (Regional + English + Hindi) for non-Hindi speaking states.
- In 1975, the union created the "Department of Official Language" and passed the "Official Language Rules" which categorized the states as regions A, B and C based on their preferences for Hindi and enforced the rules for language used in union, union-state, and union-territory, union-business and union-citizen communications for the three regions.
- The union from then on is continuing to promote Hindi in subtle ways, most recently through the 3-language formula in its National Education Policy.

The states and territories (together) have so far not been able to accept Hindi as an official language. As an example, even a less Hindi averse state like Karnataka has opted for English over Hindi and is continuing to promote the regional language of the state.

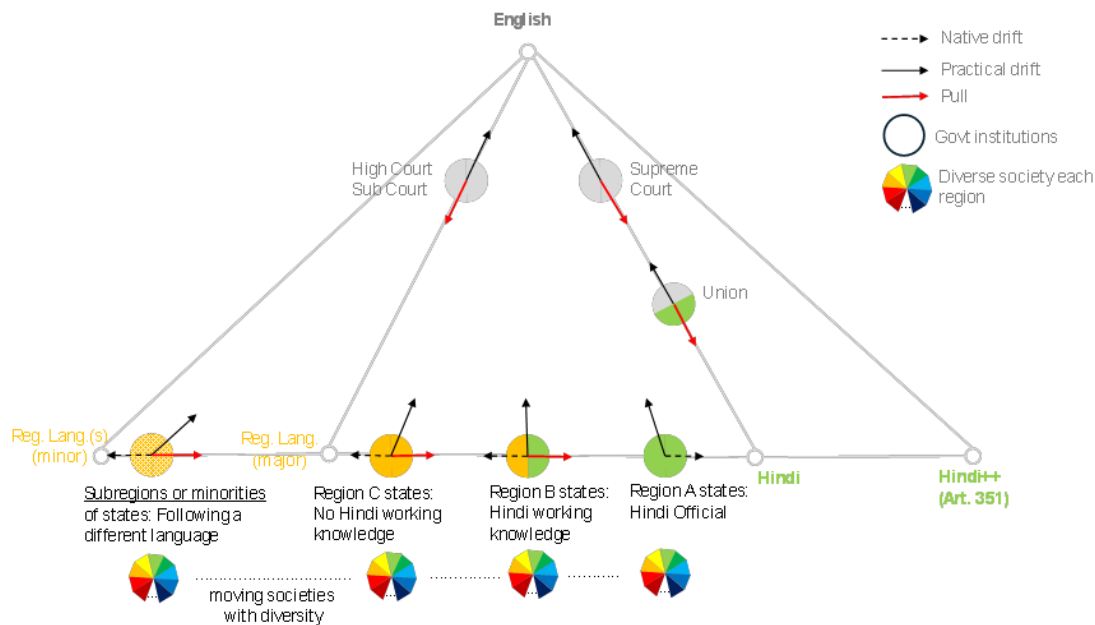
- In 1963, the state passed the "The Karnataka Official Language Act" to retain English as an official language alongside Kannada. In 1974, 1981, 1982, This act was further amended to make Kannada as official language in lower levels of administration like district and local bodies.
- In 1977, the "Department of Kannada & Culture" was formed to monitor use and promote Kannada language in the state.
- In 1994, "The Kannada Development Authority Act" was passed to create an authority (KDA) to monitor and enforce Kannada in the state and to secure Kannada in education.
- In 2015, "The Kannada Language Learning Act" was enacted to enforce Kannada in school from class I to X as either 1st or 2nd language
- In 2022, 2023, the 1994 act was made more comprehensive as the "The Kannada Language Comprehensive Development Act" which included provisions for promoting Kannada in higher education, Reservations for Kannadigas, Rules for Kannada on establishment name boards, Kannada promoting cells in all establishments, concessions/tax rebates/penalties for establishments based on compliance to Kannada promotion initiatives.

The courts of India have been relatively less impacted by the official language dilemma. The courts as per provisions in the constitution adopted English as the official language. The courts have maintained English as the official language so far successfully with states and territories additionally legislating use of regional languages in proceedings in the High courts and subordinate courts. The supreme court continues to conduct its proceedings and maintain texts in English only.

Overall, the governments of India over many years of deliberations and legislations have reached a status quo situation in the matter of adopting official languages for governments functioning, however the languages stress continues to surface within governments and in society in some form or the other.

The official languages status quo and societal stress

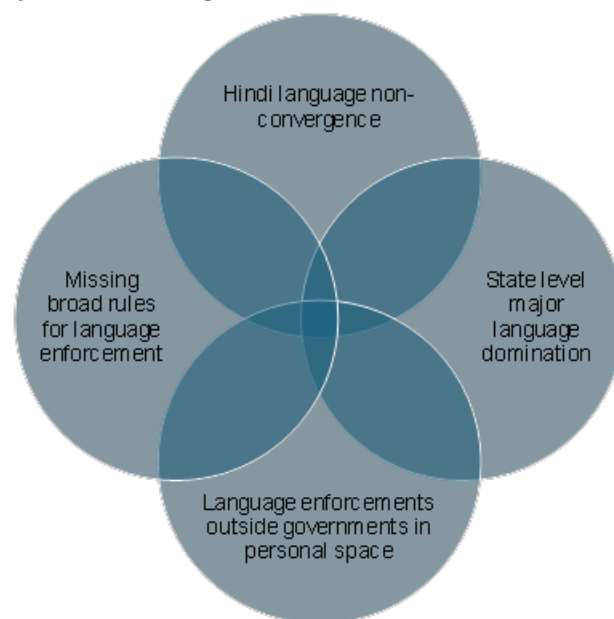
The Government institutions of India seem to have reached a 3-pole status quo in the matter of official languages, the three poles being English, Hindi and regional languages. Hindi speaking regions have adopted Hindi and English. Non-Hindi speaking regions have adopted regional majority language(s) and English (over Hindi). A second level of status quo is also emerging wherein subregions (with regional minor languages) have been coerced into adopting the majority language of the state/territory as official languages for lower levels of governance. The status quo and language rules seem to have been broadly accepted within the realms of the governments.



However, no broad acceptance can be assumed for societies as societies are diverse and dynamically moving. Moving societies are subjected to the language rules of the government of the region they move into. Further, personal aspirations make individuals practise languages other than official languages of the region. The societies therefore are under stress to adapt to the languages of the governments they interface to. The stresses become more acute when governments start imposing rules within the realm of societies disrespecting societal choices. E.g. medium of education, compulsory languages in education, Languages used on sign boards, reservations based on language in government and private institutions etc.

The root causes of language stress

Though the 3-pole status quo has settled the official language dilemma the following fundamental problems largely remain causing occasional societal stress:



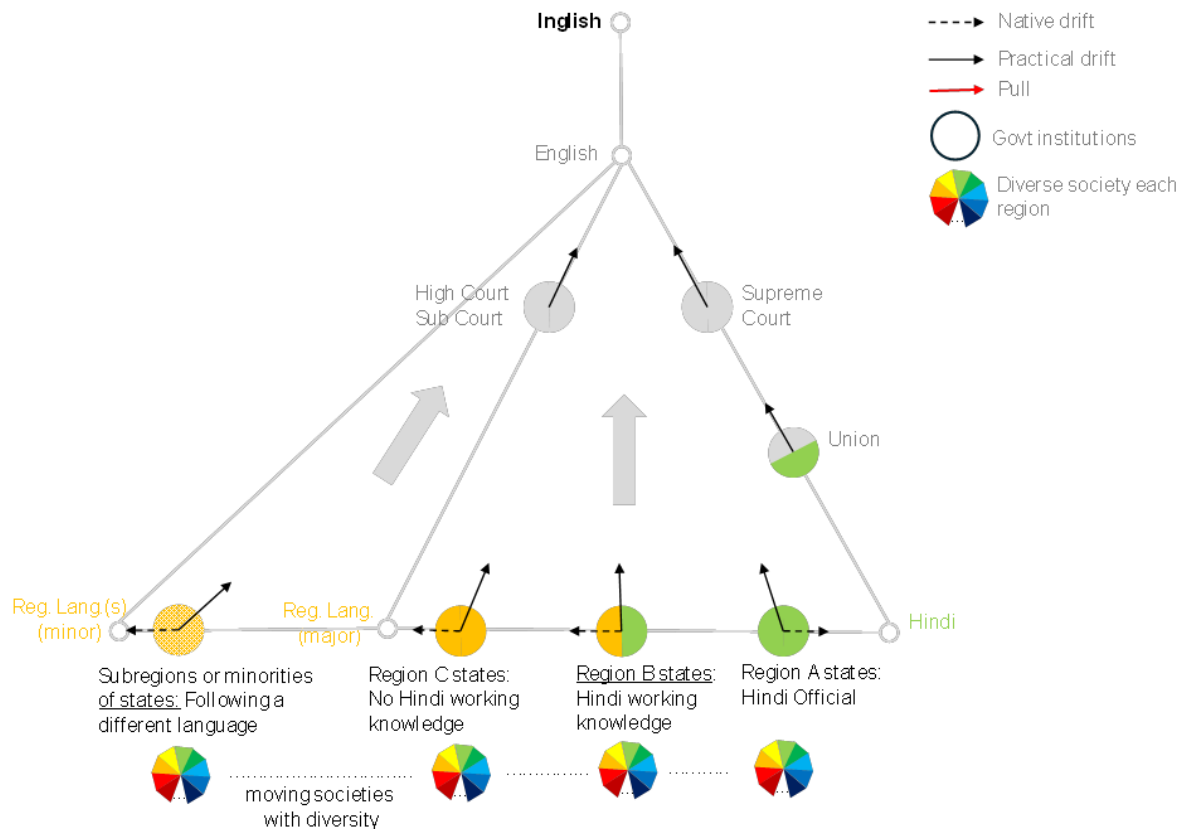
1. **Hindi language non-convergence:** The languages choices made at state/territory levels are not converging to a single inspirational language for India, Hindi, as envisaged in Art. 351 at the

union level. The union government through its departments and programs is continuing to work towards this goal, however the status quo and observed drifts in language choices at regional levels suggest that this vision will never become a reality. Art. 351 as of today seems inconsequential. Unless amended appropriately to reflect reality, this article will lead to further Government interventions which can lead to resentments in society and societal breakup. The non-convergence is also leading to non-existence of a "national language" essential for communications where language choices are inappropriate. E.g. Warning, Instructions etc.

2. State level major language domination: The states/territories are doing the same mistake as the union in imposing the majority language of the state/territory as the language of the subregions which may be speaking a different minority language. E.g. Karnataka has subregions wherein Tulu, Kodava, Konkani, Marathi, etc. are dominant. The states may be doing this only to limit the official language list to reduce overheads. However, this may also mean suppression of hidden subregional aspirations. Art. 347 may be under compromise and subregional languages may lose an opportunity to operate in lower levels of governance in states/territories.
3. Language enforcements outside governments: A diverse society is exposed to limited language(s) in its interfaces with the Government. This imposition is acceptable given the limited capacity of the Government to address society in multiple languages. However, when Government enforces language outside the realm of Government in day-to-day areas of communication e.g. announcements, name boards etc, it causes inconvenience. When language preferences are further applied to aspirational areas like education, employment etc. it leads to minimum 3-language learning requirements. Learning a new language is not easy especially when forced and this leads to societal resentment. The reasons for Government interventions in society outside government are:
 - a. Perceived language insult: Some events in society caused due to language stress are portrayed as insult to the language in the political economy. Many times, this perception precipitates as language enforcements in society.
 - b. Perceived fear of extinction: Extent of language usage in society may not be evident from observations in public places, education places, workplaces etc. Today language content is delivered privately in digital ways through eBooks, FM Radio, Satellite TV, Internet TV etc. across the globe. A language may appear less used in public places, but the language may still be in use in private places, in fact thriving. Perceived fear of language extinction leads to language enforcements in society
 - c. Perception that educating a society in a language promotes language: Government's intervention to promote language in formal and informal ways like making language compulsory in education, private establishments etc. is meaningless and an inconvenience as society learns language in better ways at home, through cinema on internet TV/Satellite TV etc. Society learns a language on its own when such requirements arise.
4. Missing broad guidelines/rules for language enforcement: The areas in which language choices should be allowed, and choices that can be made is not well specified at a broad level. A blanket enforcement leads to inappropriate use of language and societal inconvenience/harm E.g. Warnings, Instructions, Numbers, Currency, Bills, Vehicle number plates etc. cannot be in a regional language. E.g. Name plates and forms in government offices, orders/notices etc. cannot be in regional languages without translations in English/Hindi.

Relieving language stress

The occasional language stress that arises within governments and due to government interventions in society can be addressed by making necessary amendments in the constitution, implementing a 2-language formula across the regions, and following a nationwide guideline to enforce rules within society.



The proposed corrections would help to ensure national language drift in one direction and lead to a 2-pole status quo for languages in all regions, one of the poles being the single inspirational national integration language of India, and the other pole(s) being the native language(s) of the regions. Following changes are proposed:

1. Article 351 amendment

Replace the inspirational language of India with English.

- English, as the Indian extension of English
- All regional languages of India to contribute to the English language consisting of an English base with Indian extensions in script and words only.

<u>Elements of language</u>	<u>English</u>	<u>English</u>
Symbols	Standard British English	+ New regional language transliteration symbols
Words		+ New regional language words addition
Grammar		NO change

We could envision that with contribution from many regional languages, English would eventually evolve uniquely as a different Indian language deserving world recognition. Combining of English and regional languages is already observable in colloquial regional language use in society today.

- c. Department of official languages/Ministry of Home Affairs to be reoriented to the English mission with participation from regional language departments. The department shall:
 - i. Maintain English dictionary for additional transliteration symbols and words inspired by regional languages
 - ii. Develop English language learning courses (books, syllabus)
 - Basic course: Suitable for basic knowledge of English for use in day-to-day affairs.
 - Advanced course: Suitable for learning advanced formal English required for higher aspirational goals E.g. Fields related to modern sciences, English culture etc.
 - iii. Provide online language learnings and certification courses across India
 - iv. Authorize use of English learning courses (books, syllabus) in educational institutions (schools and colleges) across India

2. 2-language formula for Governments at all levels

At each level of governance, the majority practised language in society at that level will be chosen as the 1st official language of governance at that level. The 2nd language will be English which will serve as a nationwide fallback language option across all regions. This approach is to allow even minority regional languages to participate in their majority regions. Since English will be the fallback language in all regions, it will be necessary for all Indians to learn basic English. Learning basic English would unite all of India under one language, while regional languages would flourish in their regions of majority.

E.g. Karnataka

<u>Governance Level</u>	<u>1st language (Majority language at that level)</u>	<u>2nd language</u>	<u>Remarks</u>
Union	Hindi	English	
State	Kannada	English	Authoritative translations to be maintained at each level in both 1st and 2nd language
District - Kodagu	Kodava	English	
...	...	...	
District - Mangaluru	Tulu	English	
...	...	...	

3. Regional language development departments

Regional language development departments will be created for all languages in the VIII schedule. New entries into the VIII schedule shall continue to be allowed based on merit in representations made by regions aspiring to add their languages to the schedule.

The "Regional Language departments" shall:

- a. Prepare the learning material for the regional language:
 - Maintain regional language museum, relics, libraries etc.
 - Develop regional language learning courses (books, syllabus)
 - Basic course: Suitable for basic knowledge for use in day-to-day affairs. Publish language books in transliterated English for ease of learning.

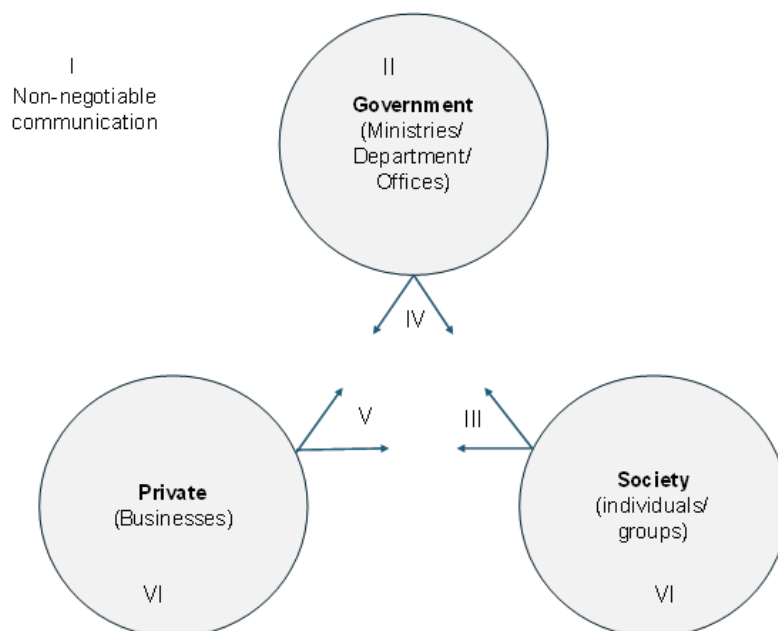
- Advanced course: Suitable for learning advanced formal language required for higher aspirational professional goals E.g. Govt. jobs, Literature, Music, Dance, Tourism, ... etc.
 - Provide online language learnings and certification courses across the world
- b. Authorize use of its learning courses (books, syllabus) in educational institutions (schools and colleges) across India.
 - c. Make regional language contributions to English
 - (i) Words (ii) Transliteration support
 - d. Promote regional language and culture in all possible ways.
 - e. Develop scientific methods to measure the advancement and use of regional language without just relying on observations in public places. E.g. Measuring stock and flow of language contributors and contributions. (stock: authors, producers, publishers of books, films, plays, songs...; Flows: sales of books, films, plays, songs).

4. Language enforcement rules/guidelines

Nationwide guidelines/rules shall be defined for choice of language in all areas in which Governments, Businesses and Society work together. The guidelines shall also list the areas in which no choice of language is allowed (non-negotiable) E.g. Numbers, Warnings etc.

Following is the proposal:

The entities involved in communication are simplified here as Governments, Private Enterprises (Businesses) and Society (individual/groups).



- a. The 1st and 2nd languages for Government shall be as per 2-language formula defined previously.
- b. Businesses shall declare 1st language in their founding documents as any regional Indian language of their choice. The 2nd language shall by default be English.

- c. Individuals shall declare their 1st language choice to governments or businesses if such provision is made available. In the interest of streamlined communication, it is advisable that governments/businesses register this preference. The 2nd language shall by default be English.
- d. Guidelines/rules shall be defined for communication within entities and between the entities shown above. The communication rules shall be based on principles of using personal liberty without causing any inconvenience/harm to any other party.

Example guidelines for illustration:

This guideline to be applied nationwide by all governments, businesses and societies.

<u>Communication Interface</u>	<u>Communication</u>	<u>Guidelines</u>	<u>Remarks</u>
I. Non-negotiables	Numbers, Currency, Road signs, Vehicle number plates, Hazard warnings etc.	- Signs & Symbols only - When supporting text is unavoidable, the publishing entities use their 1st and 2nd language.	
II. Intra and Inter Government communication	Proceedings, circulars, notices, ...	1st (or) 2nd language of union or state or regional office.	
III. Societal Response to Govt. and Businesses	Queries, Responses to notices, Feedback etc.	<u>1st (or) 2nd language of govt/private office</u>	
IV. Government provided goods or services to businesses/ society	<u>Office services:</u> Office boards, name plates, instructions, forms, notices, ...	<u>1st (and/or) 2nd language of govt. office.</u> Use preferred language information if available for notices	For services and goods use govt languages; for public places use language of region
	<u>Private goods:</u> Product name, label, ...	<u>1st (and) 2nd language of the govt. establishment</u>	
	<u>Public places:</u> Name boards, instructions, tickets	<u>1st (and) 2nd language of region.</u> Use more languages since society may be diverse	
	...		
V. Private provided goods or services to govt/society	<u>Office services:</u> Office boards, name plates, instructions, forms, notices, ...	<u>1st (and/or) 2nd language of private office</u> Use preferred language information if available for notices	NO INTERVENTION

	<u>Private goods:</u> Product name, label, ...	<u>1st (and) 2nd language of private establishment</u>	
	<u>Public places:</u> Name boards, instructions, tickets	<u>1st (and) 2nd language of region.</u> May use more languages since society may be diverse	
	...		
VI. Private and Society Internal		Personal choices	NO INTERVENTION

The proposal from (I) to (IV) may already be in force but not formalized at a national level. The proposals for (V) and (VI) may seem counter intuitive for promoting regional language, but when implemented by all states/territories will build mutual trust between governments, businesses, and societies. In fact, Government interventions in (V) and (VI) are the main causes of language stress in societies and businesses.

Examples for (V) and (VI):

- Say a company registered with Gujarati as 1st language used only Gujarati and English on its name boards in their offices in Karnataka. This should be allowed in mutual interest given that a company registered in Karnataka will use Kannada and English on its name board in Gujarat. That these companies also add regional languages on their nameboards in business interest should be welcome but not enforced.
- Say the government intervenes to enforce mandatory learning of regional language in private businesses or societies. This will lead to interference into private choices of individuals. Governments shall not practise this.

5. New framework for identifying language decline or language injustices

Many actions of the governments to enforce language rules are due to unfounded fears of language decline in society or intimidation caused by perceived language injustices. The government shall review and strengthen the frameworks for identifying and reporting language decline or language injustice. The regional language department shall periodically report the extent of use of language based on scientific measurements of stock and flow of language in society. The societies shall be encouraged to report language related injustices for review by the departments. Heavy penalty shall be imposed on offender if language injustices are indeed proven.

Summary

The language unification exercise rolled out by our constitution and pursued by the governments for several years has reached a status quo, however the status quo has 3 languages as its poles. Persuasions by Governments in language enforcements in this 3-pole status quo scenario is resulting in societal stress and division of society based on language. An approach based on imagining a new Indian dialect based on English (called English), can help to rekindle the language mission afresh and find a single national language for India alongside other regional languages (2-pole convergence) as envisioned in the constitution of India. This new mission must be supported by regional language contributions for English development and a clear uniform nationwide guideline for language enforcement to be followed by Governments at all levels.

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